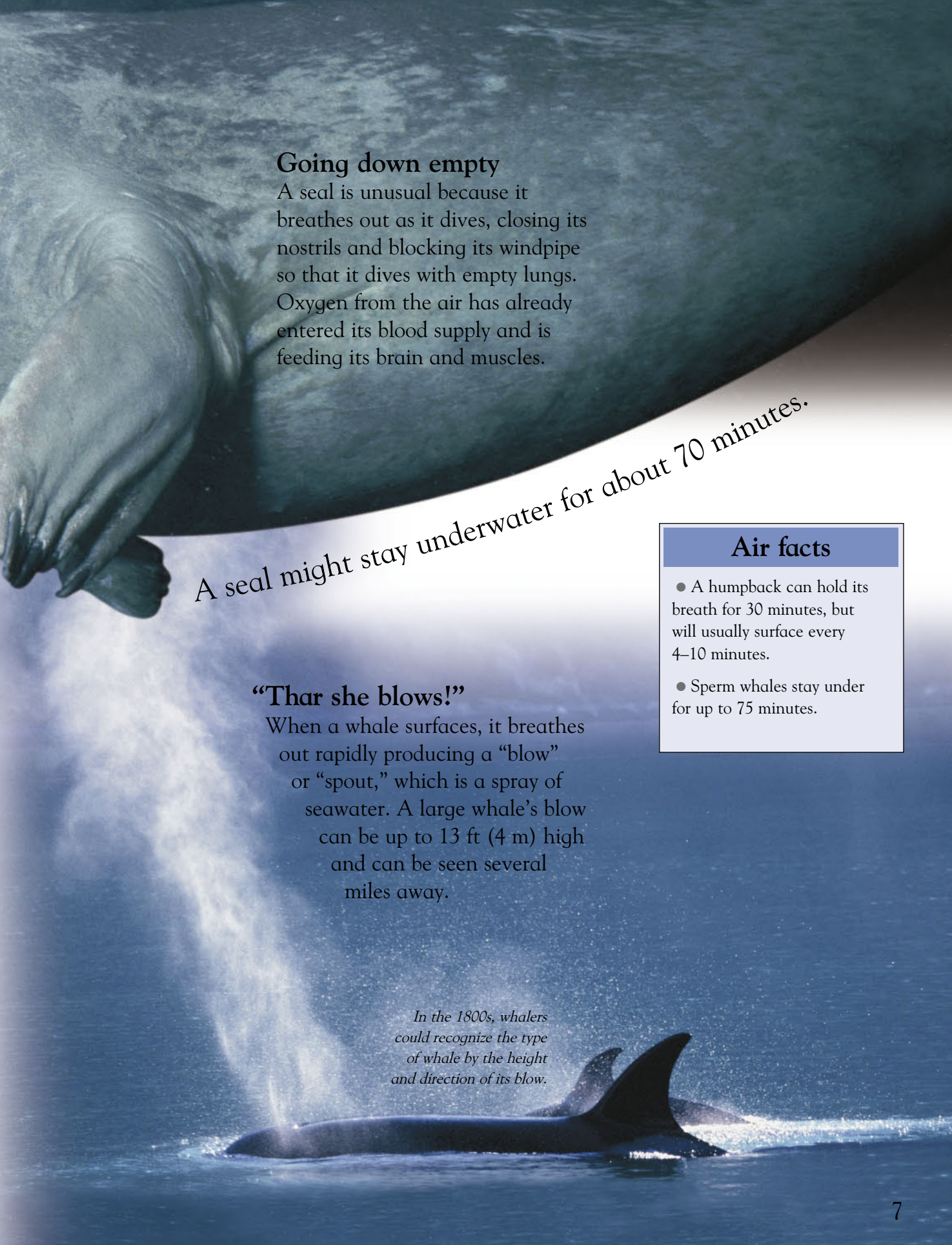


A large seal is shown diving into the water, its head and front flippers visible above the surface. The water is dark blue and slightly rippled.

Going down empty

A seal is unusual because it breathes out as it dives, closing its nostrils and blocking its windpipe so that it dives with empty lungs. Oxygen from the air has already entered its blood supply and is feeding its brain and muscles.

A seal might stay underwater for about 70 minutes.

Air facts

- A humpback can hold its breath for 30 minutes, but will usually surface every 4–10 minutes.
- Sperm whales stay under for up to 75 minutes.

“Thar she blows!”

When a whale surfaces, it breathes out rapidly producing a “blow” or “spout,” which is a spray of seawater. A large whale’s blow can be up to 13 ft (4 m) high and can be seen several miles away.

In the 1800s, whalers could recognize the type of whale by the height and direction of its blow.